Italian Rapier

Drills, Lessons, and Principles

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Preface

This document is a compilation of texts on Italian rapier fencing. Some were originally handouts, others documentation, yet others a way for me to work through a topic; most were written in preparation for classes taught at *Klingenspiel* in Vienna, others are my own training notes. All of them are living documents—each time I return to a topic, I update that chapter with new drills, ideas, and notes. For now, the material here is confined to 'rapier alone', as that is my primary focus. Once I start working more intensively on rapier and dagger, that will begin to appear here too.

Style

A fencer reading through this document will hopefully get the impression that, while it is not confined to the teachings of a particular fencing master, the approach described is stylistically coherent. I do not yet have a succinct definition of that style, but I do have some bullet points. I am looking for a style of Italian rapier fencing that:

- is at least as 'martial' as it is 'art'.
- is distinctly 'rapier', not 'heavy smallsword' or 'long sabre'.
- is based on a set of principles that are simultaneously derived from the Italian treatises and logically sound.
- has viable defensive and offensive options.
- treats the rapier as a 'thrust-and-cut' weapon the same ways as a sabre is a 'cut-and-thrust' weapon.
- integrates footwork, bladework, and body movement.
- is not linear.
- considers the empty hand (the 'other strong hand') as an integral component of every action.
- not averse to using all parts of the rapier in offence and defence (pommel, quillons, etc.).

I am not really a tournament fencer, and so my criteria for integrating something into my fencing is that I can make it work in hard sparring, that is, against an opponent who is really trying to win.

Using the Document

Although most chapters reference each other in some way,[1] all are written to work as stand-alone documents. The last chapter, *Cues and Details*, contains the central ideas from the preceding chapters, condensed into coaching cues or descriptions of detail. This is meant both as a quick reference for someone already familiar with the material, and as a starting point for someone looking for a particular topic, but wanting more detail than the index provides. The chapters on *Balance and Voiding* and *Empty Hand Basics* both contain progressive drills on a topic.

The most recent version of this document, along with the source code and sections that are still in progress, can be found at https://github.com/laugedideriksen/ItalianRapier.

[1] These cross-references are green and clickable in the PDF.

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Finding the Guard (v0.0.1)

The guard is the fencer's foundation. Ridolfo Capo Ferro describes the guard as the alphabet of the art of fencing. TK. It is also one of the most characteristic elements of many rapier styles—Fabris, Capo Ferro, and Thibault are all recognisable from the posture alone. Nevertheless, I find it to be one of the most difficult things to teach. What follows is partly an exploration of guards from various Italian sources, partly an attempt to turn those into coaching cues (see Section 1.3 of *Cues and Details*).

1. Principles

It seems to me that a guard needs to accomplish TK things:

- provide a flexible starting point for attack and defence.
- be stable, but mobile
- minimise an opponent's possible lines of attack, and thereby reduce the possibilities that a fencer needs to account for.

2. Primary Source Guards

I have included examples from three treatises: Capo Ferro Ridolfo Capo Ferro's *Gran Simulacro*, Saviolo's *His Practice*, and Fabris Salvator's *Scienza d'Arme*. These are examples of three very different postures: Saviolo is relatively upright, Capo Ferro leans back and Fabris is bent over forward. All three, however, address the same TK: mobility, TK, and limiting the opponent's options.

2.1. Capo Ferro



Figure 1: Capo Ferro's guard

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/4/40/Capo_Ferro_06.png

2.2. Saviolo: *His Practice* (1595)

In *His Practice* (1595), Vincentio Saviolo describes three guards ('wards') for single rapier. Although he writes that all three are useful in practice, he also emphasises the didactic quality of the first two: the first ward teaches nimbleness, judgement, and coordination; the second ward teaches the stoccata, the imbroccata, and the use of the empty hand. (See also Section 4.3 of *Empty Hand Basics*).

According to Saviolo the guard must 'frame your hand, your foote, and your body, all which partes must goe together, and unlesse you can stirre and move all these together, you shall never be able to performe any great matter, but with great danger' (Saviolo 1595, 8).

First Ward

Describing his first ward 'breeds a judgement of the time, and a readinesse and nimblenesse as well of the hand as the foote, together with the body: and from this you come prepared to learne other wards with more facilitie, and to have a greater insight and understanding in many things' (Saviolo 1595, 16) (Figure 2). On his account, 'many Nations use this ward in fight verie much, especially with the single rapier, both Italians, French-men, Spaniards, & Almanes' (Saviolo 1595, 16).

> [The scholler must] stand with his right foote formost, with his knee somewhat bowing, but that his body rest more upon the lefte legge, not stedfast and firme as some stand, which seeme to be nayled to the place, but with a readines and nimblenes, as though he were to perform

some feate of activitie … his [weapon] hand be free and at libertie from his body, and that the ward of his hand be directlye against his right knee … [and] the pobnt (*sic*) be directly against the face of his [opponent].

— Saviolo (1595, 8–9)



Figure 2: Saviolo's first ward

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/archive/4/40/20130915232741%21Saviolo_1.jpg

Second Ward

Second, it starts from his 'second ward' which he describes as follows, somewhat contrary to the accompanying illustration (Figure 3):

[The scholler must] place his right legge formoste, a little bending the knee, so that the heele of his right foote stand just against the midst of his left foote, holding his swoord hand close on the outside of his right knee, with his swoorde helde in shorte, least his adversarye should gaine the same, ever keeping the poynte directlye on the face or bellye of his enemye

— Saviolo (1595, 17)



Figure 3: Saviolo's second ward.

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/archive/3/3b/20130915232754%21Saviolo_2.jpg

Third Ward

In contrast to the previous two wards, the description of the third ward (Figure 4) is rather vague. First, he writes:

> … this third warde, which notwithstanding is quite contrarie to the other two. Because that in this you must stand with your feet even together, as if you were readie to sit down, and your rapier hand must bee within your knee, and your point against the face of your enemie
>
> — Saviolo (1595, 19)

And a few pages later:

> When you perfectlie understand your weapons, it maie serve you otherwise, so that you hold not your swoord hand within your knee, for if you finde your enemie to beare his swoord long, being in distance, you maie sodenlie beat it aside with your swoord
>
> — Saviolo (1595, 22)

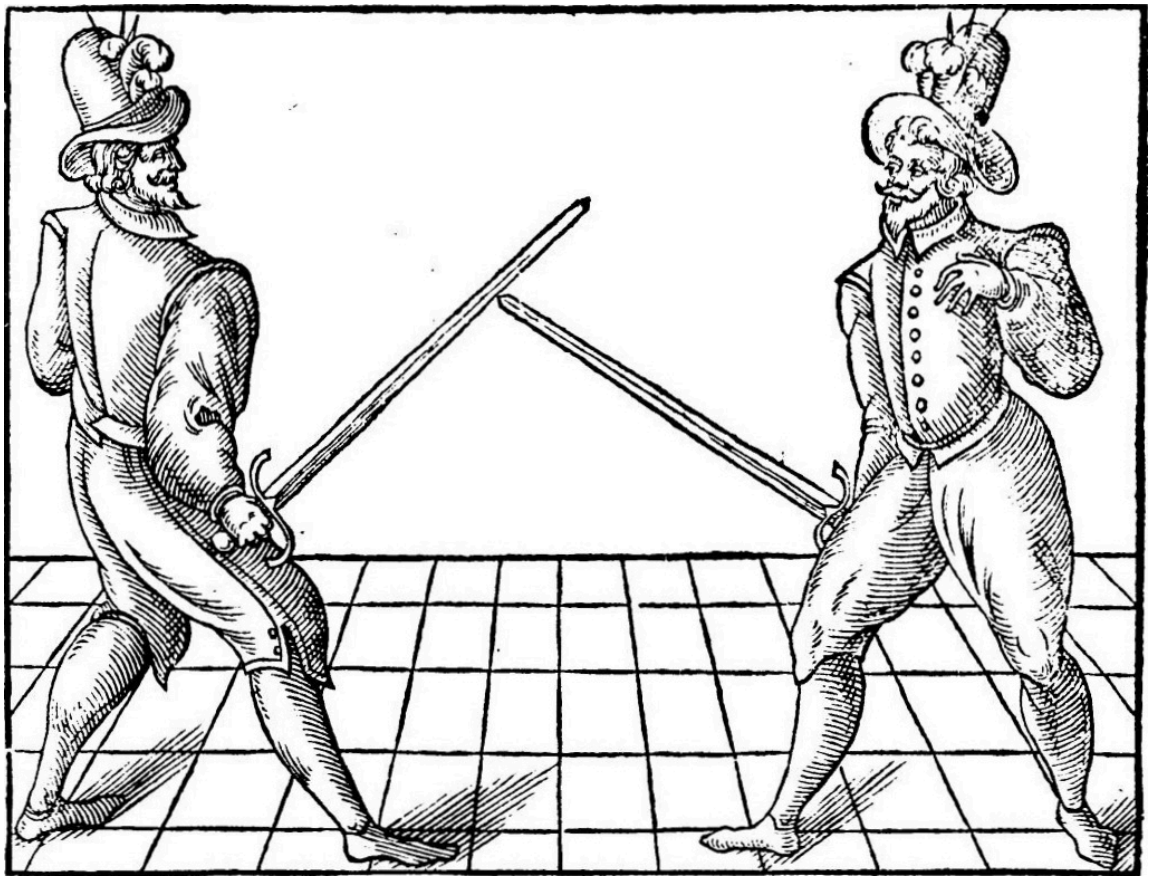


Figure 4: Saviolo's third ward

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/archive/4/40/20130915232805%21Saviolo_3.jpg

2.3. Fabris

Fabris' guards are in many way the opposite of Capo Ferro's. It is also a style with which I have very little experience, and so in no way should what I write here be taken as gospel.

3. Summary

TK. The most obvious conclusion is that there are many ways to skin the poor, proverbial cat. Looking closer at each of the treatises, it becomes clear that within each system several guards not only exist, but are necessary. TK. Thinking of them and practising them as 'ready positions' is didactically useful, but eventually a fencer must learn to also think of them as postures one may pass through in the course of an exchange.

Stringere (v0.0.1)

Stringere is perhaps one of the most ambiguous concepts in Italian rapier fencing. Part of this might be due to the lack of good English (or German) translations of the word. In English one often finds 'gain', or 'find', or 'stringer'. Some teachers also use 'constrain' which, while not a direct translation, gets at the nature of the action. I use either 'gain' or the italian 'stringere', although the latter results in somewhat awkward passive constructions. This document does not try to make sense of how the concept is presented in different sources.[2] Instead, I have tried to describe how I think about, and teach, stringere. The first section describes my notion of stringere—what it is, what it does, and how it does it. The second section contains the drills I use to teach it. If I teach the topic on its own, I usually spread it across two classes, but I use many of the same drills when working on other concepts, reviewing the principles of stringere in the process.

1. Principles of Stringere

David Biggs (2025b) summarises the technique of stringere as:

> to gain an opponent's blade, you want to place a greater length of your blade over a lesser length of theirs. And you want to turn your true edge - the edge you would usually try to cut someone with - toward their blade, and aim your point at their silhouette or just past it.

While there are fine points of stylistic difference (some insist on pointing the true edge toward the ground, for example), this summarises most of the mechanical details. It does not, however, explain why one would want to perform a stringere in the first place.[3]

On my view, a stringere does two things: it limits the opponents options and keeps the fencer protected while doing so. It also puts the fencer in a position to increase pressure on the opponent.

2. Drills

These are the drills I use when teaching the topic of stringere. If I teach the topic on its own, I usually divide it into two classes. The first class covers drills Ia.–IIb.; the second class reviews drills Ic. and IIa., and covers IIIa–e.

I do each drill for three rounds on each side (inside/outside): first round very slowly, second round at a pace that feels smooth, third round pushing the pace just beyond what is comfortable. Contrary to other topics, where I will let pairs of students work on a drill for a longer period of time, I have each pair do a drill one time each before rotating to a new partner.

[2] David Biggs has written an excellent blogpost (2025) trying to do just that.
[3] He does so elsewhere, however (Biggs 2024a; 2024b; 2024c; 2025b).

I. Basics.
   a. A gives a line; B performs a stringere with a gathering step; if A sees an opening for a direct attack, A strikes.
   b. As Ia., but B's gathering step must bring them into middle range. If A sees no opening for a direct attack, B strikes with a thrust in opposition.
   c. As Ib., but if A sees an opening for a direct attack at any point, they strike.

II. Common reactions to a stringere.
   a. A gives a line; B performs a stringere with a gathering step; A performs a disengage (cavazione) and a thrust in opposition.
   b. As Ib., when B attacks, A counters *stesso tempo*, with or without a void, with or without an empty-hand parry.

III. Counters to IIa.
   a. As IIa.; B counters *a dui tempi*.
   b. As IIa.; B counters *stesso tempo* with a void.
   c. As IIa.; B counters *stesso tempo* with without voiding, with or without an empty-hand parry.
   d. As IIa.; B attacks into A's disengage with a thrust in terza (stoccatta).
   e. As IIa.; B counters with a counter-disengage (countracavazione) and a thrust in opposition.

Balance and Voiding (v1.2.0)

This document is an elaboration on materials and principles taught over the course of several classes at *Klingenspiel* in Vienna. The focus of these lessons were on ways of actively using balance to prepare and initiate actions, especially voids. To make that possible, however, a fencer must be able to control and manipulate their balance, both in the guard and in transitory and preparatory positions. For many fencers, however, balance is something they try to retain (to 'keep one's balance'), not something they actively use. To remedy that, the first section of this document contains drills and exercises aimed at developing an awareness of balance in various positions and movements. It also contains descriptions of how I manipulate my balance to initiate various common pieces of footwork. The second section combines these movements into simple solo- and partner drills. The third and final section contains partner drills that gradually build from simple action/reaction to something resembling constrained sparring.

1. Fundamentals

The human body has two centres of balance. One, the head, is gimballed, the other, the 'centre of gravity', is located somewhere around the navel; moving either causes the rest of the body to follow. It can be helpful to think of the rapier as a third centre of balance. It is not as potent as the other two, but especially a heavier rapier can significantly alter one's balance. For the purposes of this chapter then, one can think of 'balance' as the equilibrium between the two centres, the rapier, and whatever is counteracting gravity—usually one or both feet. The distance and orientation of your feet, your 'base', is another important factor. Standing on both feet, set roughly shoulder-width apart provides a stable platform, standing on the toes of a single foot does not. As we shall see, however, stability is not always desirable, and neither is a broad, stable base.

The first step toward intentionally manipulating one's balance is to become sensitive to it. Therefore, before working on any of the material below—preferably before reading any further—take your rapier and move as you usually would, observing your balance as you do so. As you work through the rest of this chapter, endeavour to come back to this awareness; it is the basis for everything below.

Guard

While this chapter is agnostic to the style of your guard, but there are a some things that I have found helpful:[4]

- Place the majority of your weight on the balls of your feet. This does not mean lifting your heels of the floor, however!

[4] For a thorough discussion of rapier guards, see *Finding the Guard*, as well as Section 1.3 of *Cues and Details*.

- While in your guard, slowly move your one or both of your centres of balance in a direction until you cross the point where you can no longer stay in place and have to catch yourself.
- Practice moving right up to that 'point of no return' and stay there.
- Change a small detail—the angle of your back foot, the distance between your feet ('North/South' and or 'East/West'), or the angle of your upper body—and observe how that changes any of the above.

When working through the rest of this chapter, periodically come back to the guard and see if anything needs altering.

Drop step

The drop step is used across martial arts, but I became aware of it through the work of Rory Miller. In essence, a drop step in an intentional free fall. One can think of it as lifting one foot off the ground without first taking one's weight off of it, and the catching oneself before hitting the ground. The human body is pretty good at keeping itself from landing face-first on the floor, and so it can help to focus on removing the leg swiftly, and let the catching take care of itself. For a detailed description, see Rory Miller's blog post on the topic.[5]

Altered drop step

A limitation of the drop step is that it always results in a movement along the line between one's feet. By shifting one's weight or leaning in the direction wants to 'fall', however, it is possible to alter that trajectory, at the cost of telegraphing one's intention. When practising this, start by clearly separating the two stages of the movement: first shift weight and/or lean, then perform a drop step. Experiment with different amounts of leaning and shifting, from barely noticeable to falling over —both ends of that spectrum can be very useful.

Lunge

What I have described as an altered drop step above, is almost identical to the footwork of a rapier lunge.[6] All that is missing, is to add the upper-body parts of the lunge (extending the arm, turning the torso, getting behind the hilt, etc.). A few things to keep in mind:

- the order of movement is: extend arm–lean/shift–drop step–catch–recover or advance. Always extend the arm first!
- at no point during the lunge should one push off of the back foot.[7]

Once that begins to feel smooth, find the 'point of no return'—the point beyond which one has to commit to the drop step. Then practice getting to that point as quickly as possible, without kipping

[5] As Miller point out, it is also possible to drop straight down by 'lifting' both feet at the same time. This is not very idiomatic to Italian rapier fencing at all, but can nonetheless catch an opponent by surprise.

[6] Or at least the way I teach it. The proverbial cat is making itself scarce again.

[7] This assumes that one leaves the back foot in place during the lunge, which I firmly believe is the correct thing to do.

over into a full lunge. That point, and being able to explosively get to it, goes a long way towards feinting convincingly (see also 'Explosive Impetus' in *Cues and Details*).

Traverso Weapon Side

A traverso, from the word for 'going across', is mechanically similar to a lunge, but instead of forwards, one moves diagonally or sidewards. When 'traversing' to the weapon side, it is often easiest to go diagonally forward, as that is closest to the strong line. One thing to note about a traverso to the weapon side is that it brings the blade off-line. While this does create an opening—which can be addressed with the empty hand—it also allows one to attack from different angles.

Traverso Empty-hand side

For the same reason that a traverso to the weapon side tends to move diagonally forward, a traverso to the empty-hand side tends to move diagonally backward. Contrary to a traverso to the weapon side, it is possible to leave the rapier on-line; one can think of leaving the blade in place and moving the body around it.

Passata Sotto

Shift weight back, then drop step The passata sotto is quite an athletic movement and an excellent way to pull one's groin if one is not used to it.



Figure 5: Plate 16 (cropped) from Philibert de la Touche's *Les Vrais Principes de l'Espée Seule* (1670). The figure on the right has performed a passata sotto.

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/4/47/Les_Vrays_principes_de_l%27esp%C3%A9e_Seule_La_Touche_Planche16.jpeg

The basic order of movement remains the same: extend arm–shift/lean–quasi drop step. The trick is to shift the weight backwards while leaning (bending at the hip) forwards.

Backwards lunge

The backwards lunge is a rare movement, and that for a reason. But it is a workable alternative for anyone unable to do a passata sotto. The mechanics are the same as a lunge, with two significant differences: both point and head are facing away from the direction of travel. The resulting order of movement is: extend arm (forward)–lean/shift (backwards)–drop step (backwards)–recover(forwards) or retreat (backwards).

This may initially seem a little schizophrenic, which also makes it a good exercise

Incartata (Volte)

Incartata (or volte) and scanzo are often spoken about as alternatives to one another. In many cases they are, but they differ significant in the details.

Scanzo

Shift weight, then 'throw' shoulder.

Gathering Step

Different ways of finishing—as a regular step, or any of the movements above.

Passata

As lunge + trav L.

2. Simple Drills

TK. These drills work regardless of whether both fencers hold their weapon in the same hand or not.

On Cue

This drill is a simplified version of classic *salle* footwork and should be done with weapons. The instructor is limited to four signs: lunge, traverso left, incartata, and passata sotto. The goal is to help the students find a guard that lets them move in all directions.

On Cue with Gathering Step

As the drill above, but the instructor can also signal a gathering step forward or backward (see 'Gathering Step' above). For the purposes of this drill, I use the regular signals for 'step forwards' and 'step backwards'.

On Cue with Free Steps

As 'On Cue' above, but instead of standing still, the students move freely backwards and forwards. The goal is to train changes of direction, and retaining control of one's balance while in motion.

Stick I

Partner drill. Both partners place the palm of the weapon hand against opposite ends of a dowel or broomstick. One leads, the other follows using lunges, traversi left, incartata, and back lunges. The

goal is to not drop the stick. A certain amount of pressure on the stick helps you feel what your partner is doing.

Stick II
Same as above, but adding steps forwards and backwards.

Stick III
Same as Stick II, but there is no designated leader and follower. Think of it as both partners following, not both partners leading.

Bind I–III
The same as Stick I–III, but using rapiers in the bind. Once this works, add disengages.

Voiding
Partner drill. A stands in their guard, B attacks with a thrust in opposition on the inside or the outside. If the attack is on the inside, A voids with a incartata or scanzo; if the attack is on the outside, A voids with a traverso left. In both cases, A 'leaves' their blade in the middle as described above.

Voiding in Motion
As above, but A is freely stepping backwards and forwards. B keeps the distance until they attack.

3. Complex Drills

Each of the following drills is made up of a series of steps and are designed to be practised progressively—first step one, once that works at full speed, step one and two, then one and two and three, etc. Start each iteration slower than you think and speed it up to something like sparring speed over 4–8 repetitions.

The goal of each action is to hit the opponent while not getting hit, but it is not the goal of the drill to win at all costs. Each action should counter the previous action, but especially as speed and intensity increase, not every action will be successful. That is fine. Analyse what went wrong and try again. As with the simple drills, focus on balance and on using it to initiate each action.

These drills encourages a style of fencing that emphasises control over explosiveness. Control does not mean strength, however. A weaker fencer with good structure and good technique (strong on weak, etc.) has little issue controlling a much stronger fencer. Nonetheless, fencers who have based their style on being faster than their opponents may find it frustrating.

3.1. First Drill

Fencers (A and B) start in middle distance (where either can hit the other with a lunge).

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside; B disengages; A rebinds. On a disengage of their

choice, A lunges, striking B with a thrust in opposition instead of rebinding.

1. If A attacks on the inside, B voids with a volte or scanzo; if A attacks on the outside, B voids with a traverso L. In either case, B 'leaves' their blade in the middle line, as described in section 1 above.

1. A parries B's blade with their empty hand, and strikes B with a stramazone to the head. The stramazone can be done with or without a step of the back foot.

3.2. Second Drill

Fencers start at a distance where either can strike the other with a gathering step and a lunge.

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside with a gathering step; B disengages and lunges, striking A with a thrust in opposition.
2. If B attacks on the inside, A voids with a volte or scanzo; if B attacks on the outside, A voids with a traverso L. In either case, A 'leaves' their blade in the middle line, as described in section 1 above.
3. As 2 above, but instead of disengaging and striking, B may instead take a step backwards. If they do, A finishes the gathering step as a step forward, effectively resetting the situation.
4. As 3 above, but from the initial position, either fencer may initiate the action with a gathering step. At this point, this drill begins to resemble a constrained for of sparring, and the intensity should eventually reflect that.

3.3. Third Drill

This drill combines elements of the two drills above. Fencers start at a distance where either can strike the other with a gathering step and a lunge.

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside with a gathering step; B disengages and lunges, striking A with a thrust in opposition.
2. A either takes B's disengage as a tempo to strike them with a thrust in opposition,1 or voids B's attack with a volte/scanzo or traverso L, depending on whether B attacks on the inside or the outside.
3. If A attacks into B's disengage, B voids A's attack with a volte/scanzo or traverso L.
4. If B voids, A parries B's blade with their empty hand, and strikes B with a stramazone to the head. The stramazone can be done with or without a step of the back foot. If A voids, B parries with the empty hand, etc.
5. Instead of disengaging and striking when a seeks the bind, B may take a step backwards. If they do, A finishes the gathering step as a step forward, effectively resetting the situation.

6. As 5 above, but from the initial position, either fencer may initiate the action by seeking the bind with a gathering step. Adding this step makes for an extremely complex drill and in most cases it is best left out.

3.4. Improvising Drills

Once two fencers have repertoire of actions and are comfortable moving within the idiom of their style (whether that is as broad as 'seventeenth-century Italian rapier' or as narrow as 'Rapier after Capo Ferro'), they can begin to improvise drills like the ones above. Doing so is a great awareness drill, and can be tailored to reinforce a fencer's strength or to address their weaknesses. Drills like these can also given a focus other than balance, e.g. moving off line, using the empty hand, blade-foot coordination, etc. I have found the following guidelines to be helpful:

- Agree on a starting distance and action, e.g. a beat and a thrust, seeking a bind, etc. The drills above are ambidextrous and symmetrical, but that is not a requirement.
- Each iteration of the drill should be done slowly and then sped up over 4–8 repetitions.
- Regardless of the speed, every action should be done with full force aiming at good targets.
- Try to keep each 'turn' to one or, at most, two actions each.
- Each action after the first should be what Rory Miller calls a golden move (Miller 2016): it protects you, hurts your opponent, puts you in a better position, puts your opponent in a worse position.
- Keep the exchanges relatively short (2–5 'turns' at most), otherwise what started as a fencing drill becomes a memory game.

Empty Hand Basics (v1.3.2)

This document is an attempt at a curriculum covering the basic use of the empty hand[8] in Italian rapier fencing. It consists of four sections: principles, knife work, rapier work, and primary source plays. The first section sets out the principles which the remainder of the document attempts to put into practice. The second sections contains a collection of drills and free play exercises to be done with training knives. This is not an attempt at teaching knife fighting, but a way of teaching and practising mechanics and movement patterns without the added complexity of maneouvering a 110cm length of steel. The third section contains drills and free play exercises focused on using the empty hand with the rapier. The fourth section contains a collection of plays from various primary sources that use the empty hand.

How To Use this Document

Each section of this document builds on the previous: the principles laid out in section one lay the foundation for the mechanics and movements in section two on knife work. The second section contains drills and exercises to familiarise the student with using the empty hand. Once those mechanics have become familiar, the third section combines them with the blade- and footwork of Italian rapier fencing. Finally, the plays at the end of the third section integrate the empty hand as part of longer sequences. Each drill is focused on a single technique and several drills can be combined to form decision drills. The free play exercises are meant to be a transition between drilling and sparring; they are constrained and often asymmetrical, but should be carried out with increasing intensity. The point, is not, however, to 'win' these exercises, it is to begin applying techniques from the drills under pressure.

In an ideal world, the sections should be covered in order over the course of several weeks. That, however, is hardly viable when teaching a rapier class in a fencing club. The next best thing is to pick out a combination of knife and rapier drills and exercises covering the same topic, and use that as the basis for a class. Even so, I would advice against introducing the primary source plays before the class has a good grip of the fundamentals.

A Note for (and against) Left-handed Fencers

As always, drills and exercises need to be adapted when fencing (against) an opponent who wields their weapon in a different hand than you do. For some drills in this document, it should suffice to switch the side of attack (inside/outside), for others, I have made a note suggesting a modified version. Even so, there might be exercises that are simply not appropriate when fencing 'leftie'

[8] Throughout this document, I use the term 'empty hand', instead of 'off hand' or similar. I do so to emphasise it as an essential component of fencing with the rapier 'alone', rather than an unfortunate byproduct of human physiology.

against 'rightie'. In those cases, trying to force a technique to work is a waste of time, and the better solution is for the fencer on the receiving end to fence with their 'other strong hand'.

Terminology

Broadly speaking, there are four ways to use the empty hand in Italian rapier fencing: parrying, taking over, trapping, and displacing.[9] In an empty-hand parry, the opponent's weapon is deflected first, and usually only, with the empty hand. This is often combined with a simultaneous (STESSO TEMPO) attack with the rapier. As a rule of thumb, empty-hand parries do not work against cuts.[10] When the opponent's blade is parried or displaced with the rapier, the empty hand can take over controlling their weapon, freeing up the rapier for offensive use. Trapping is any form of taking control over the opponent's weapon. This ranges from the complex traps and disarms found in some Spanish sources to simply grabbing any part of the opponent's weapon within reach.[11] Finally, the empty hand can be used to displace the opponent's blade and create an opening (similarly to a BATTUTA).

While there are examples of all four types of empty-hand actions in Italian rapier treatises from the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, parrying and taking over are by far the most common. For that reason, they are the focus of this document. Although it seems like an obvious thing to do, I am not aware of treatise describing the offensive use of the empty hand in the form of punching, slapping, eye-poking, etc. Whether that accurately reflects how people fenced at the time is another matter altogether.

1. Principles

It seems to me that there are three fundamental principles for successfully integrating the empty hand with the rapier:

1. The empty hand must not get in the way of the rapier.
2. The empty hand must be ready to use without any preparatory movement.
3. The empty hand must be an intentional part of every action.

These three principles are in addition to the general principles of fencing in general and rapier fencing in particular.

From (1.) it follows that the empty hand is most easily used on the inside. On the inside, any thrusting attack to the head and torso can be deflected with the same movement of the empty hand: a semicircle from just above the head to somewhere outside the left hip. Using the same motion to cover the entire inside also means that the movement removes a decision point, as opposed to

[9] Fencing terminology is infamously inconsistent and this topic is no exception. These are the terms I have settled on.

[10] They can, but it is a bit sketchy. See e.g. Di Grassi's *His True Arte of Defence*.

[11] Opinions differ on whether it is possible to hold on to a sharpened rapier or not; to my knowledge, it has been some time since anyone tried it out.

holding the empty hand in the middle and moving it up or down depending on the opponent's target. Doing this motion from the top down rather than the bottom up means that gravity works with you and against your opponent. Depending on context, it can be useful to 'tilt' this imaginary semicircle towards the opponent, by moving the end point forward and upward. In this way, the parrying movement can also be used to displace and to take over when the opponent's blade is on the inside.

From this in combination with (2.), it follows that, in the guard, the empty hand should be held somewhere around head-height and close to the face. Assuming a *capoferrian* guard, the body must be angled so that the empty hand can protect both face and torso without having to turn the torso first. Exactly what this looks like will vary from fencer to fencer.

Parrying, displacing, and taking over on the outside come with some downsides, but should nonetheless be part of one's repertoire. The most obvious downside is that they require crossing the arms, thus necessarily limiting the weapon arm's movement upward or downward. Another downside is that they require more precision. Using the sweeping motion described above, actions on the inside have a wide margin of error—a parry will work whether one catches the opponent's blade with the hand, wrist, or forearm. Such a motion is not practical on the outside, instead actions on the outside tend to be horizontal. At the same time, most rapier schools use a guard where the outside is 'closed'. Attacks on the outside therefore tend to follow from invitations, BATTUTI or feints. By drilling responses to these that incorporate the empty hand, one can alleviate some of those downsides.

So much for platonic fencing. These are principles, not commandments and they will not apply to every situation.[12] Nonetheless, this document is concerned with the basics, and for that these principles will apply nine times out of ten.

2. Knife Work

As I wrote in the introduction, this section does not describe a system of knife fighting. Many of the drills and patterns are taken from or inspired by various knife systems, but the goal here is to get used to using both hands in concert, not to become proficient at using a knife. Working with knives when learning to use the empty hand has several advantages. For one, knives are much shorter and much lighter than rapiers. This makes the discrepancy between the hands is smaller. The lighter weight also allows more repetitions of new movements before fatigue becomes an issue. The most important distinction between knife training and rapier fencing, however, is that knife fighting is not fencing—there is no fancy footwork, no seventeenth-century flair.

[12] Such as your opponent's avoiding your empty-hand parry by lifting their tip over your hand, as is suggested in *Den Ridderlige og Adelige Fecht-Konstis* (1646). Any empty-hand action immediately following that will likely start from below, as that is where the hand is.

Although not all knives are created equal and the same goes for training knives, each different implement affords different ways of training. I make the people in my class work with all of them—plastic bowies, LARP daggers, aluminium trainers, rolled-up newspapers, etc. A trainer I find especially useful for higher-intensity work is a ~16cm roll of yoga mat, wrapped in gaffer's tape so that only 1–2cm are exposed at one end.[13] It is cheap, stiff enough to be usable, yet soft enough that neither student nor teacher need to worry about anyone getting hurt.

As for posture, grip, and footwork: keep it simple. Feet shoulder-width apart, weight on the balls of your feet, slight bend in the knees, shoulders almost square to the opponent/partner, posture relatively upright, weapon slightly in front of the body but not too far, and empty hand has described above.[14] Hold the weapon point down or point up (hammer or sabre grip to suit preference and implement) depending on exercise and do not lock the wrist. In terms of footwork, think boxing or Filipino triangle footwork, not fencing. And whatever you do, do not lunge!

2.1. Drills

Dui Tempi

1. Implement: larger blade, e.g. bowie held point up.

   A attacks with a diagonal cut to the head (number '1' or '2').

   B blocks with a cut to the forearm, takes over the parry with the empty hand, and strikes A with a cut or a thrust.

   Note: experiment with different placements of the empty hand in relation to the blade.
2. As above, but A attacks with a thrust to the face or chest.
3. Implement: smaller blade, preferably held point down.

   A attacks with a diagonal thrust to the outside of B's neck.

   B blocks with the forearm of their weapon hand.

   A clears the block out of the way (downwards) and finishes the attack.

   Note: this drill and the following does not work R against L.
4. As above, but B blocks with their empty hand.

   A clears the parry again, this time more sidewards than downwards.

   Flow: this drill can be combined with number 3 into a flow/reaction drill. Depending on B's block, A will have to clear differently. B can also block first with the weapon hand and then with their empty hand, forcing A to clear twice.
5. As 3 and 4 above, but A's attack is aimed at the inside of B's neck.

[13] I have taken this idea from Scott Babb's knife fighting system, *Libre*.

[14] This is intentionally vague. Find something that allows you to move well and is distinctly different from your rapier guard. Don't overthink it.

Flow: These two can be combined with 3 and 4 to create a flow drill where both A and B have to react to each other.

6. Implement: smaller blade, held point down.

   A attacks with a forehand to B's face/neck.

   B blocks with the forearm of their empty hand, seeking to counter (*in due tempi*) to A's trunk.

   A rips down through B's block, while either checking their weapons shoulder or delivering a palm strike to their face.

   Note: This drill is not suitable leftie against rightie.

7. Implement: small or large blade, point up or point down, especially useful with a bowie.

   A attacks with a forehand to B's face/neck.

   B blocks with their weapon hand (or a stop-cut to the arm with a bowie).

   A clears B's block to the outside with their empty hand before it connects.

   Note: This clearing works best from below.

Stesso Tempo

1. Implement: blade of any size, held point up or point down.

   A attacks with a diagonal cut to the head (number '1' or '2').

   B steps toward A while simultaneously blocking the attack with the empty hand and striking A with a cut or thrust.

   Note: try out different forms of empty-hand blocks—hand, forearm, trapping, or the kind of elbow 'crash' found in systems like *UC* and *SPEAR*.

2. Implement: blade of any size, held point up or point down.

   A attacks with a thrust to the trunk.

   B parries with their empty hand while striking A with a cut or a thrust.

3. Implement: blade of any size, held point up or point down.

   A attacks with a horizontal cut/thrust to the outside face or neck.

   B steps in, thrusting A in the chest while moving the empty hand across to the outside of their face, checking A's arm/elbow.

Free Play

Free play exercises fall somewhere between sparring and drilling. On one hand, they are meant to stress test techniques and concepts that have been drilled. On the other, they are an opportunity to experiment with ways of getting to those techniques. To that end, the intensity of the exercise should be adjusted to match the goal—less for experimentation, more for stress testing. In any case, the focus should remain on using both hands together, not on winning.

1. A fights as usual, but B cannot use their empty hand.

2. As above, but B is up against a wall.[15]
3. As above, but it is A against the wall.
4. Both can use the empty hand, but one is against the wall.
5. Fight as usual, but in a confined space.
6. Limited targeting: the only valid targets are e.g. the back, the face, or the trunk.
7. Multiple hits: Do not reset after each hit, but continue until someone has been hit multiple times.
8. As above, but pursue a situation where the opponent is unable to counter, even if given tempo to do so.

3. Rapier Work

Before attempting any of the drills below, spend some time integrating the lessons learned from the knife work into your rapier basics—especially stance and footwork. Look for the feeling of symmetry between weapon hand and empty hand that has hopefully developed with the knife.

The following drills differ in some ways from the plays traditionally found in rapier treatises. They are short. Few have more than three steps. This is to keep the focus on the technique of movement being drilled. I have also tried to emphasise offensive actions, as the treatises tend to emphasise defensive ones. Much like primary source plays, however, not every drill is likely to work in sparring, and not every drill will work for every fencer.

3.1. Drills

Dui Tempi

1. A attacks with a diagonal cut to the head or neck (number '1' or '2').

   B parries in QUARTA or SECUNDA,[16] depending on the attack, takes over the parry with the empty hand, and strikes A with a cut or a thrust.

   Note: experiment with different placements of the empty hand in relation to the blade.
2. As above, but A attacks with a thrust to the face or chest.
3. As above, but A attacks with an inside thrust to the abdomen, and B parries in hanging PRIMA or low QUARTA.
4. A attacks with a thrust to the abdomen in TERZA or SECUNDA.

   B parries with a hanging SECUNDA to their outside, steps forward with a PASSATA/ Profilwechsel, grips the hilt or base of A's blade, and simultaneously pulls with their empty hand

[15] The focus here should be on using weapon and empty hand in concert to safely close the distance. To that end, use control, not speed and explosiveness.

[16] Following the convention of *Den Ridderlige og Adelige Fecht-Konstis* 1646, parries are denoted by the orientation of the blade. Thus, a parry in SECUNDA is what later systems call a TERZ-parry.

while thrusting with the rapier under A's blade. Ideally, A's blade should be trapped between B's empty hand and their quillons.

Note: depending on the length of the rapier, it may be necessary to keep the weapon hand relatively far back during the PASSATA.

Variation 1: instead of thrusting with the point, B can keep their rapier point-down and hit A in the face with the hilt. This is particularly nasty if the rapier has straight quillons.

5. As above, but instead of levering A's blade between empty hand and own quillons, B frees their blade, lifts their arm behind them, and thrust A from above.
6. As above, but instead of gripping A's blade, B pushes the elbow of A's weapon arm.[17] This is especially effective if the rapier parry has the force of a BATTUTA.
7. A attacks on the inside with a diagonal cut to the head or shoulder.

   B parries with a hanging parry (OCTAV), steps forward with the back leg and grips A's forearm with their empty hand. Riposte at will.
8. Same as above, but A attacks on the outside and B parries accordingly (SEPTIM).

Stesso Tempo

1. A engages B with STRINGERE on the inside, seeking to close the distance.

   As soon as B's point comes within reach, A simultaneously clears it out of the way and thrusts B in QUARTA.

   Note: 'had B been a shrewd person' they would have never let A get that close. Well, B isn't always shrewd.
2. A engages B with STRINGERE on the outside, seeking to provoke a disengage.

   B disengages to the inside when they feel forced to do so.

   As soon as B disengages, A advances or lunges, while simultaneously clearing B's rapier with the empty hand and thrusting B in QUARTA or SECUNDA (see note).

   Note: Depending on how early B disengages, A's timing will change drastically. Making the final thrust in QUARTA will provide A with more protection, while thrusting in SECUNDA will leave slightly more space for the empty hand to work.
3. As above, but B thrusts in opposition directly following their disengage.

   As A parries and thrusts, they can either stand their ground or step to their inside with a traverso.[18]
4. A thrusts at B.

   B simultaneously parries and counters with a thrust.

[17] Cf. the *Fiore de'i Liberi* adaptation below.

[18] Yes, this is towards, not away from, the incoming attack. The idea is to further displace the opponents blade, while keeping it under control.

Free Play

1. A fences as usual, but B cannot use their empty hand.
2. As above, but B is up against a wall.
3. As above, but it is A against the wall.
4. Both fencers can use their empty hand, but one has their back against the wall.
5. Multiple hits: Do not reset after each hit, but continue for until someone has been hit multiple times.
6. As above, but pursue a situation where the opponent is unable to counter, even if given tempo to do so.

4. Primary Source Plays

The following plays have been adapted from a variety of rapier treatises. Where the author gives several responses to an action, only those using the empty hand have been included. For the sake of brevity, I have rewritten them in a more schematic form, but I highly recommend consulting the original sources, or translations thereof.

Capo Ferro plays are based on Wilson and Swanger's translation. The *Fiore de'i Liberi* play is based on translations by Michael Chidester and Colin Hatcher. The Saviolo sequence is based on the English original. All three are available on Wiktenauer.

4.1. Capo Ferro No. 20



Figure 6: Plate 20 from Capo Ferro's *Gran Simulacro*.

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/wiki/File:Capo_Ferro_20.png

C STRINGERE D on the outside.

D disengages, seeking to strike C with a STOCCATA.

Option 1: C parries in QUARTA with a beat of the front foot.[19] C then strikes D's face in SECONDA with a PASSATA, while gripping D's wrist with the empty hand from above.

Option 2: C parries in QUARTA while closing with the back foot. C then strikes D's face in SECONDA with a lunge, while gripping D's wrist with the empty hand from above.

4.2. *Fiore de'i Liberi* 14d

Fiore de'i Liberi is a treatise from before rapiers were a thing and, as such, the fencing it describes differs somewhat in style from Italian rapier treatises. This technique still works, however, especially for more athletic fencers. I have included it here as an example of a more forceful use of the empty hand.

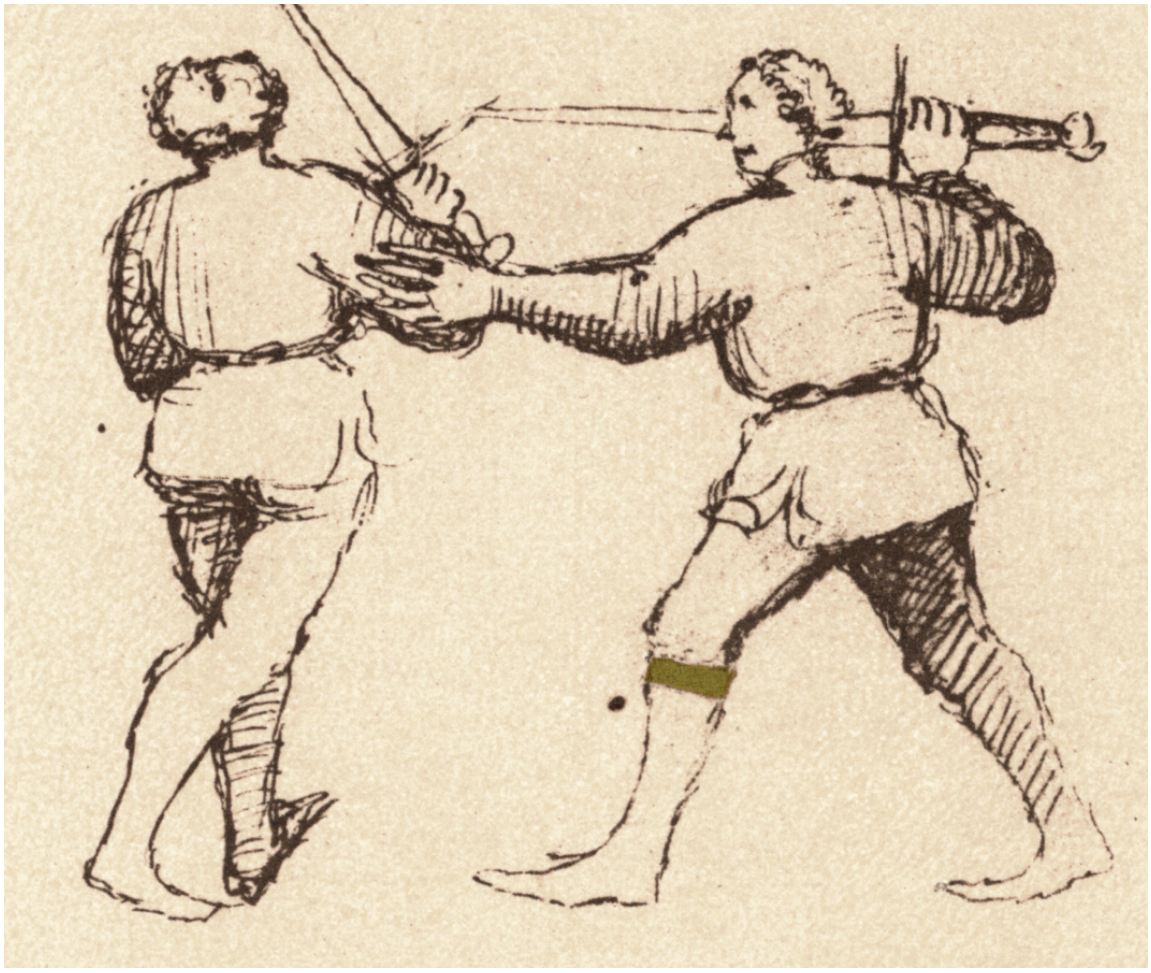


Figure 7: Illustration 14d from the *Pisani Dossi* manuscript.

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/7/7f/Pisani-Dossi_MS_14a-d.png

A attacks B on the inside with a thrust in PRIMA or SECUNDA.

B parries in QUARTA.

As B parries, A steps forward with a PASSATA and shoves B's elbow across their body.

[19] I take this to mean an *appell*, but also a transfer of weight to the front foot.

B then ‘wrap[s his] sword around [A’s] neck from behind, and [A] will have no defense to this.‘

Note 1: A’s initial thrust can either be direct or somewhat diagonal, thus forcing B to parry further out than otherwise. This can be combined with different angles in the PASSATA, to the point where it almost becomes a TRAVERSO.

Note 2: I am aware of two illustrated versions of *Fiore de’i Liberi*. In one, A is depicted with the right foot in front, in the other with the left foot in front. Especially with long rapiers, I have found that a PASSATA works better than a lunge.

4.3. Saviolo’s Second Ward

This sequence from Saviolo’s *His Practice* (1595) makes for an excellent drill, with two caveats. First, the sequence relies on Saviolo’s somewhat idiosyncratic footwork. Second, it starts from his ‘second ward’ which he describes as follows, somewhat contrary to the accompanying illustration (Figure 8):

> [The scholler must] place his right legge formoste, a little bending the knee, so that the heele of his right foote stand just against the midst of his left foote, holding his swoord hand close on the outside of his right knee, with his swoorde helde in shorte, least his adversarye should gaine the same, ever keeping the poynte directlye on the face or bellye of his enemye
>
> — Saviolo (1595, 17)



Figure 8: Saviolo's second ward.

Source: https://wiktenauer.com/images/archive/3/3b/20130915232754%21Saviolo_2.jpg

M STOCCATA with a small step right around the circle.

S STOCCATA and empty-hand parry with a step right around the circle in counter-time.

M right foot counter-time, IMBROCCATA to S's face and empty-hand parry with a left-foot step toward S's left hand.

S empty-hand parry ('beating the thrust … outward toward the left side') with step right around the circle in counter-time, then IMBROCCATA to M's face.

M empty-hand parry while stepping his right foot towards S's left hand in counter-time and then STOCCATA to S's belly.

S empty-hand parry downward while stepping right foot towards M's left hand in counter-time and then STOCCATA to M's belly

M empty-hand parry to their right side, stepping diagonally backwards with their right foot in counter-time and STOCCATA to S's head.

Addressing Non-technical Weaknesses (v0.0.1)

This is a collection of things that have helped me address non-technical weaknesses I have encountered—things like grip, elbow- and shoulder endurance, etc. This is not meant as a coherent method for developing fencing-specific strength and conditioning, but rather a grab-bag of observations and movements that I have found helpful.

- Most of my non-technical issues have gone away by getting stronger and more mobile. I already have a solid aerobic base, but others may want to add that to the list.
- For the historical fencer, a biceps curl is a surprisingly functional movement.
- Inverse wrist curls are great against elbow pain.

Cues and Details (v0.0.1)

This chapter contains a collection of cues that I have found useful for teaching Italian rapier. Most of these should be self-explanatory, but I have tried to include some of my thoughts, as well as some of the over-corrections I have observed, for each. It also contains a number details that either didn't fit anywhere else, or are generally applicable.

1. Cues

1.1. General

Explosive Impetus

Cue: Most actions (lunge, incartata, etc.) consists of two parts: an explosive impetus, and an attempt to not face-plant as a result of that. Focus on the explosive part, and let the rest take care of itself.

Notes: Sometimes students are too focused on finishing an action in a particular position, or on looking a particular way when they move. Both of these are useful things to work on from time to time, but they can also lead to slow, tense, awkward movement. Focussing instead on the explosive impetus, and letting the body worry about keeping your nose from making contact with the floor, can be a good way to alleviate that. In my experience, moving well is a case where form follows function.

Pitfalls and Over-corrections: Not everyone has good control of their body. That is not an eternal judgement, but a weakness on can—and should!—work on. For those who are not there yet, however, this cue is unlikely to work right away; it can, however, be a good starting point for working on body control. A few pitfalls I have observed:

- Putting way too much energy into the explosive part and ending up in a bad position.
- Focussing so hard on being explosive that one forgets the purpose of the movement.

'Long Guard'

Cue: Create a straight line from your elbow, through the cross of the hilt, to the point of the rapier.

Notes: When holding the rapier in what some call a 'long guard', that is, the rapier is held parallel to the ground, some have a tendency to stick out their elbow, or otherwise uncovering their weapon arm. This cue often helps with that.

Pitfalls and Over-corrections: Fencers who are not yet comfortable gripping the rapier (see below), often start doing weird things with their wrist to create the line.

1.2. Specific Movements and Actions

Incartata/Scanzo: end position

Cue: Head over shoulders over arse.

Notes: When first learning rotating voids, especially incartata and scanzo, many tend to finish the movement leaning backwards or with their head at a weird angle. Focus on finishing with the head and upper body stacked on top of each other—that way it is easier to change direction.

1.3. Developing the Guard

Finding the Guard

2. Details

Gripping the Rapier

Different treatises give different (often vague) instructions for holding the rapier. Saviolo gives what is perhaps the most important piece of advice: "For your Rapier, holde it as you shall thinke most fit and commodious for you" (Saviolo 1595, 7). Here are a few details that have helped me to that end:

- don't squeeze the handle. As a matter of fact, hold it as loosely as possible and only give it a squeeze at the moment of impact in e.g. a parry.
- find a way to let the weapon 'hang', for me that is between the hook of my index finger and the pinky-side of the base of my palm (the *hypothenar eminence*).
- don't push the index finger all the way through. Depending on the geometry of the hilt, my index finger wraps around the quillon at the distal joint or phalange (the joint or segment furthest away from the hand).
- I sometimes rest the pommel against my wrist
- in the same way as there is no one best guard, there is no one grip that is best for every situation, find a way to hold the rapier that allows you to move it in your hand.

2.1. Footwork

Front Foot

The line of the front foot should bisect the opponent's centre of balance.[20]

Knees over Toes

There is nothing inherently dangerous about the knee moving out in front of the toes e.g. in a lunge. There is, however, something inherently dangerous in forcing both knee and ankle into an unfamiliar range of motion by throwing the majority of your bodyweight onto it with great motivation. There are good reasons to train this range of motion, only some of which have to do with fencing. When fencing, however, there are also good reasons to not always to into the deepest lunge of which one is capable, mainly that it can be slow and awkward to get out of. As is so often the case, there are costs and benefits.

[20] I first heard this one from George Livermore of the *1595 Club*'s Milano chapter.

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